Tibet, trying to stabilize military relations in the borderlands, and yet finding themselves increasingly heading towards confrontation.

Confidence-building and incursions

In 1993, India and China agreed to keep border forces to a minimum level 'compatible with friendly and good neighbourly relations' and eventually to reduce force levels. The agreement prohibited military exercises in zones along the LAC and provided for prior notification of exercises. The agreement also asked both sides to ensure that air intrusions did not occur. In any case, there were to be verification measures to determine force levels at the border. A 1996 agreement was even more detailed. It reaffirmed the reduction of forces along the border. It also aimed to reduce combat tanks, infantry combat vehicles, artillery, and missiles. Both militaries would exchange data on forces and armaments and establish arms limitations at the LAC. Large military exercises in advanced areas were to be avoided. Air flights near the LAC were banned, and if needed, they were to be notified. There was to be no firing within two kilometres of the LAC, and demolitions were to be communicated in advance. Flag and other meetings were to be held regularly, and communication between medium- and high-level border authorities was to be strengthened. Finally, early clarification of the LAC, especially where they had differences, and an exchange of maps based on their respective perceptions of the LAC was to happen 'as soon as possible'.

As confidence-building measures go, the 1993 and 1996 initiatives were thorough and very much in line with the kind of measures that NATO and the Warsaw Pact had negotiated during the Cold War; indeed, they were inspired by them. At the heart of the various measures were restraints on the use of force at the LAC, commitments by the two sides to withdraw if challenged, and the holding of consultations locally and/or at higher military–bureaucratic levels in the event of stand-offs between the two forces. Each has some specifics that were different. During the 2020 Ladakh